

Social network no-nos

The risks posed by uncontrolled sharing of information are immense. Find out what not to tell
URL: <http://bit.ly/juRa2V>

99% Android phones vulnerable

Calendars, contacts and other sensitive data stored on Google's servers are under threat of being leaked.
URL: <http://bit.ly/mq2DRK>

Post-sales Service

Customer services leave a lot to be desired

Kapil Rustagi

readersletters@thinkdigit.com.

Ankur, a Mumbai-based software professional was excited about his acquisition of a brand new HDTV during the recent World Cup series. But his joy was short-lived as the TV malfunctioned in a few days of purchase. To add to the agony of this working professional, the amateur dealer and services centres made his life miserable.

Though post-sales service is a basic consumer right, he is considered a priority only till purchase. The moment the consumer asks for post-sales service or support, it turns into a pain. The retail business in our country has come a long way, but, post-sales support leaves a lot to be desired.

The general perception of an average consumer is that resellers are not liable

for post-sale services. Resellers must recognise that putting up a "guarantee or warranty is by the company not by us" board doesn't absolve them of their duties. Since consumers are unaware of their rights, resellers frequently redirect consumers to service centres. Making consumer run between resellers and service centres is nothing but sheer harassment. If a matter goes to the consumer court, apart from the product company, both reseller/ dealer and service centre can be made parties to a consumer's complaint.

Many companies have a separate customer services division. However, many of these services are provided through call centres. Quite often, executives are unskilled in the particular field and end up offering nothing but apologies. The toll-free

helpline numbers either don't work or change. If they do work, it takes hours to get through. Also, it is almost impossible to converse with the same executive the consumer had shared his grievance with. In no situation will they give you an official company contact number, leaving you at the mercy of executives.

Nothing can replace consumer awareness. Undertake pre-purchase market research. Ascertain the quality of post-sales services rendered by resellers to existing consumers on the internet, especially social networks which are effective tools. In case of complaints, first contact the dealer and then service centre. If this fails, try to approach



We can help!
If you're facing a problem with your purchase, write to us at help@consumermate.com

the top management of the company through their web sites or social media networks. In case of ultimate failure of all approaches, contact consumer forums by filing a complaint against them all. 

COMPLAINTS RECEIVED

Mobile Phones

Zen phone with service centre for past two months

Question: I bought a Z90 mobile in the name of Vinod Pareta. Two months ago, the display of the mobile disappeared. I went to Kota (Raj) service centre to repair it but he didn't give me the mobile even after 2 months. Now I plan to go to consumer court and media, but before this, I request you to kindly look into the matter seriously and respond as soon as possible. I have the invoice and service centre receipt. Kindly do the needful as soon as possible.

Contacted By: Rakesh Kumar Pareta

Answer By Consumermate:

Dear Rakesh,
Two months is a really long time. You have a very good case if you have the receipts and other documents. I would strongly

suggest moving to consumer court against the service centre and the company.

Sony Ericsson service centre can't repair phone even after a month

Question: On 3rd March, 2011, I had given my Sony Ericsson j105i to the service centre 'Accel Frontline Service' at the Drive in Rd Branch due to a display problem. They gave me a job sheet (SE311AAD10156) and said it would take two days maximum. After six days, the service centre told me that it would take 10 more days. Now 1 month has passed.

I'm really frustrated of hearing lame excuses.

Contacted By: Jigar Acharya

Answer By Consumermate:

Dear Jigar,
This is a defective service and false promise case. Unfortunately, it's not strong

enough to go to consumer court as the relief you'll get from Court can at best be a replaced device. Try calling them up as much as possible and persuade them to repair it sooner. Also call up Sony Ericsson head office/corporate office and complain to them as well. Write down the name of the person whom you talk to, the time and date. This helps in future if things get out of hand. Also it builds a lot of pressure on them if you tell them the names of people whom you spoke to and dates when you talked to them. I hope this will get the matter settled. If, after repeated calls and attempts, it's still not repaired then go to Consumer Court. You can claim relief from Court even after sending a plain notice to the service centre but the relief is worth the case only after there is a delay of 45 days or more. It's not the law, but generally consumer courts consider 30 days as normal delay.